Preface and acknowledgements

So here we are, people … Twenty-odd years have come and gone. What a ride. I can honestly say it's been filled with every bit of emotion, from heartache and failure to celebration and triumph. I guess that's all part of life, and, for someone who is still fairly young, I can count myself lucky to have gone through so much already. These experiences will stand me in good stead, of that I'm pretty sure!

During the roller-coaster ride, I've met people all over the world, from all walks of life – from the man sweeping the streets to presidents and even the royal family. Not bad for someone who comes from an underprivileged background, hey?

I've only ever played team sports and, with this in mind, I want to say thank you to everyone who I've shared a team with, be it football, rugby or cricket. From the age of six till now! It's been a treat to play alongside each and every one of you lads, so thank you!

To all my coaches – especially Duncan Fletcher – who helped me through it all. Not sure how you men put up with me. Thank you. Fletch, you were the one who suggested that I open the batting, and we both know it worked out pretty well in the end. You are truly a legend.

To my manager, Donné Commins, who has stood by me through it all … If it wasn't for you, Don, I'm not sure where I'd be today. You're a gem of a woman. Thank you from the bottom of my heart!

To all my sponsors – sorry, just too many to name over the last two decades – thank you for allowing me the privilege of using and endorsing your products. They have all been of the highest quality! To have sponsors from the age of ten, I was truly blessed.

To my former opening partner Gary Kirsten … Gazza, the touching words you wrote in the foreword, bro, made me shed a tear or two, you shit!